

## Comparative Public Policy

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**Overview:** This course introduces undergraduates to the comparative study of public policy in advanced economies. What are the policy challenges facing advanced democracies in the twenty-first century? In what ways are the economies of Europe and the United States similar and in what ways are they different? Why do economic institutions and public policies vary between advanced economies, and how does this variation affect growth, inequality, and responses to external shocks? Topics include welfare states and redistribution, education and skill formation, gender inequality, labor market institutions, unions and wage-setting, taxation, immigration, public and private debt, housing, and green energy policy.

Students will develop familiarity with policy variation in these domains across Europe and the United States and will write a research paper on a topic of their choice. In doing so, students will refine their skills as social scientists by developing and empirically assessing explanations for cross-national variation in public policy outcomes. Throughout the semester, students will be encouraged to think critically about conventional contrasts between Europe and the United States. By the end of the semester, students will be equipped to contribute in a theoretically and empirically informed way to debates about public policy responses to contemporary challenges in the United States and beyond.

### Requirements:

Weekly reading: Students are expected to complete the week's readings before the first lecture of the week. The assigned material amounts to 60–80 pages per week, involving excerpts from longer scholarly works.

In-class midterm (Week 7): multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 25% of course grade.

In-class final exam: multiple choice, short answer, and essay. 25% of course grade.

Initial research proposal (Week 6): This is a two-page paper proposal. You should identify a policy area in which the United States differs from a European country of your choice (the more specific the better). Sketch out three possible explanations for this variation. We will meet individually to discuss these proposals. 10% of course grade.

Research paper (Week 12): This is a fifteen-page research paper in which you propose an explanation for the policy variation that you identified in your research proposal and provide evidence for your explanation based on your own research. It is imperative that you address two alternative explanations for the variation you document and provide evidence that weighs against these explanations and supports your own. 30% of course grade.

Participation: active participation in class based on substantive engagement with the readings is expected and is worth 10% of your course grade. In this course, we will uphold the

University's code of conduct and values regarding open intellectual inquiry and equal respect for all class members.

**Electronic devices:** Laptops are permitted for note-taking and for referring to course readings. Please be conscious of the fact that browsing the internet during class is distracting for the students sitting around you. If you plan to browse the internet during class time, expect to be called upon!

**Plagiarism:** Plagiarism is a serious breach of the University's code of conduct. It is assumed that you have carefully reviewed the University's policy on plagiarism. Your use of AI must adhere to the University's policy. Please note that you are unlikely to succeed on the midterm and final exam if you have not studied the readings in detail and thought about them yourself.

**Accessibility:** The University is committed to equal access for students with disabilities. Students with disabilities who have been approved to receive academic accommodations by the University must contact me as soon as possible so that the relevant accommodations can be made.

### **Week 1: Challenges of advanced economies (2 lectures)**

Alvaredo, Facundo, Lucas Chancel, Thomas Piketty, Emmanuel Saez, and Gabriel Zucman. "The elephant curve of global inequality and growth." *AEA Papers and Proceedings* 108 (2018): 103-108.

Oesch, Daniel. *Occupational Change in Europe: How Technology and Education Transform the Class Structure*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013.

Yared, Pierre. "Rising government debt: Causes and solutions for a decades-old trend." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 33.2 (2019): 115-140.

### **Week 2: How national trajectories differ (2 lectures)**

Hassel, Anke, and Bruno Palier. "Tracking the Transformation of Growth Regimes in Advanced Capitalist Economies." In *Growth and Welfare in Advanced Capitalist Economies: How Have Growth Regimes Evolved?* Ed. A. Hassel and B. Palier. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2021.

Lupu, Noam, and Jonas Pontusson. 2023. "Introduction." In *Unequal Democracies: Public Policy, Responsiveness, and Redistribution in an Era of Rising Economic Inequality*, eds. N. Lupu and J. Pontusson. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Thelen, Kathleen. "The American precariat: US capitalism in comparative perspective." *Perspectives on Politics* 17.1 (2019): 5-27.

### **Week 3: Comparing welfare states (2 lectures)**

Esping-Andersen, Gøsta. *The three worlds of welfare capitalism*. Cambridge: Polity, 1990 (selections).

Danforth, Benjamin. “Worlds of welfare in time: A historical reassessment of the three-world typology.” *Journal of European Social Policy* 24.2 (2014): 164-182.

Garfinkel, Irwin, Lee Rainwater, and Timothy Smeeding. *Wealth and Welfare States: Is America a Laggard or Leader?* Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010 (selections).

Blanchet, Thomas, Lucas Chancel, and Amory Gethin. “Why is Europe more equal than the United States?” *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 14.4 (2022): 480-518.

#### **Week 4: Education and skill formation systems (2 lectures)**

Iversen, Torben, and John Stephens. “Partisan politics, the welfare state, and three worlds of human capital formation.” *Comparative Political Studies* 41.4-5 (2008): 600-637.

Culpepper, Pepper, and David Finegold. *The German Skills Machine: Sustaining Comparative Advantage in a Global Economy*. New York: Berghahn, 1999 (selections).

Häusermann, Silja, Michael Pinggera, Macarena Ares, and Matthias Enggist. “Class and social policy in the knowledge economy.” *European Journal of Political Research* 61.2 (2022): 462-484.

#### **Week 5: Gender differences in the labor market (2 lectures)**

Rosenbluth, Frances, and Torben Iversen. *Women, Work, and Politics: The Political Economy of Gender Inequality*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2010 (selections).

Autor, David, David Dorn, and Gordon Hanson. “When work disappears: Manufacturing decline and the falling marriage market value of young men.” *American Economic Review: Insights* 1.2 (2019): 161-178.

Cortés, Patricia. “Immigration, household production, and native women’s labor market outcomes: A survey of a global phenomenon.” *European Economic Review* 158 (2023): 104545.

#### **Week 6: Labor market institutions and dualization (2 lectures)**

Saint-Paul, Gilles. “The political economy of employment protection.” *Journal of Political Economy* 110.3 (2002): 672-704.

Margarita Estévez-Abe, Torben Iversen, and David Soskice. “Social Protection and the Formation of Skills: A Reinterpretation of the Welfare State.” In *Varieties of Capitalism: The Institutional Foundations of Comparative Advantage*, eds. Peter Hall and David Soskice, 145-183. New York: Oxford University Press, 2001.

Häusermann, Silja, and Hanna Schwander. “Varieties of dualization? Labor market segmentation and insider-outsider divides across regimes.” In *The age of dualization: The changing face of inequality in deindustrializing societies*, ed. P. Emmenegger et al., 27-51. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012.

## **Week 7: Unions, wage-setting, and competitiveness (2 lectures)**

Hancké, Bob. *Unions, central banks and EMU: labour market institutions and monetary integration in Europe*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2013 (selections).

Dustmann, Christian, Bernd Fitzenberger, Uta Schönberg, and Alexandra Spitz-Oener. “From sick man of Europe to economic superstar: Germany’s resurgent economy.” *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 28.1 (2014): 167-188.

Johnston, Alison. “Always a Winning Strategy? Wage Moderation’s Conditional Impact on Growth Outcomes.” In *Growth and Welfare in Advanced Capitalist Economies: How Have Growth Regimes Evolved?*, eds. Anke Hassel and Bruno Palier. New York: Oxford University Press, 2021.

## **Week 8: Immigration and integration policy (2 lectures)**

Wallace Goodman, Sara. *Immigration and Membership Politics in Western Europe*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2014 (selections).

Dancygier, Rafaela. *Dilemmas of Inclusion: Muslims in European Politics*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2017 (selections).

Fitzgerald, David. *Refuge Beyond Reach: How Rich Democracies Repel Asylum Seekers*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2019 (selections).

## **Week 9: Politics of taxation (2 lectures)**

Cusack, Thomas R., and Pablo Beramendi. “Taxing work.” *European Journal of Political Research* 45.1 (2006): 43-73.

Ganghof, Steffen. *The Politics of Income Taxation: A Comparative Analysis*. Colchester: ECPR Press, 2006 (selections).

Hope, David, Julian Limberg, and Lukas Haffert. “The hidden cost of tax regressivity at the top.” *British Journal of Political Science* 56 (2026).

## **Week 10: Credit, debt, and demand (2 lectures)**

Ferguson, Niall, and Moritz Schularick. “‘Chimerica’ and the global asset market boom.” *International Finance* 10.3 (2007): 215-239.

Crouch, Colin. “Privatised Keynesianism: An unacknowledged policy regime.” *The British Journal of Politics and International Relations* 11.3 (2009): 382-399.

Wiedemann, Andreas. *Indebted Societies: Credit and Welfare in Rich Democracies*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2021 (selections).

### **Week 11: Housing policy** (2 lectures)

Schwartz, Herman, and Leonard Seabrooke. “Varieties of Residential Capitalism in the International Political Economy: Old Welfare States and the New Politics of Housing.” *Comparative European Politics* 6 (2008): 237-261.

Reisenbichler, Alexander. *Through the Roof: Housing, Capitalism, and the State in America and Germany*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2025 (selections).

Charles, Kerwin Kofi, Erik Hurst, and Matthew Notowidigdo. “The masking of the decline in manufacturing employment by the housing bubble.” *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 30.2 (2016): 179-200.

### **Week 12: The politics of fiscal consolidation** (2 lectures)

Tooze, Adam. *Crashed: How a Decade of Financial Crises Changed the World*. New York: Penguin, 2019 (selections).

Walter, Stefanie, Ari Ray, and Nils Redeker. *The Politics of Bad Options: Why the Eurozone’s Problems Have Been So Hard to Resolve*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2023 (selections).

Hübscher, Evelyne, and Thomas Sattler. “Austerity and populism.” *Annual Review of Political Science* 29 (2026).

### **Week 13: The green transition** (2 lectures)

Genovese, Federica. “Sectors, pollution, and trade: How industrial interests shape domestic positions on global climate agreements.” *International Studies Quarterly* 63.4 (2019): 819-836.

Nahm, Jonas. *Collaborative Advantage: Forging Green Industries in the New Global Economy*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2021 (selections).

Gazmararian, Alexander, and Dustin Tingley. *Uncertain futures: How to unlock the climate impasse*. Cambridge University Press, 2023 (selections).